Reading the Stones

What Old Records Teach

Open Projects

Robin Ohara

About the Speaker

Robin Ohara, archaeologist of the Straw Hat Pirates

- Reads the Poneglyphs
- Passed the archaeology exam on Ohara at eight
- Lost a library, and learned from it
- Believes knowledge is safest when many people hold it, and that every project deserves more than one keeper

What This Deck Shows

- **Cover:** the first slide, with the talk's title.
- **Parts:** a section slide opens each part.
- **Labels:** a grouping inside the heading.
- **Cards:** labeled groups and examples.
- **Tables:** a header row and plain cells.
- **Links:** inline, in lists and in cards.

This deck is also a sample: each slide shows one thing a deck can hold.

1

Why Records Disappear

Most losses are slow, quiet and preventable.

The Slow Losses

- The record lived in one place
- One person understood it
- Nobody left a key

The One-Keeper Problem

- One person knows where everything is
- Nobody else can read it
- Then they leave, tire or fall ill
- The text stops mid-line

What Survives

- Records that were copied
- Records in a common script
- Records that came with a key

Why It Survived

- It was read in every generation
- Strangers made copies
- Mistakes were corrected in the margin

A Good Model: Example Project

A public archive that lets anyone copy, read and correct its records, and credits every volunteer by name.

2

Six Habits

None of them is new, and all of them are easy to skip.

Six Habits That Keep a Record Alive

- **Copies:** more than one, in more than one place.
- **Plain words:** written for the next reader.
- **A key:** a glossary and a map of the record.
- **Readers:** a front door and a friendly reply.
- **Documentation:** dated, owned and kept true.
- **Open doors:** anyone may check and correct.

HABIT 1

Make Copies

- More than one copy
- In more than one place
- Held by more than one person

A Good Model: Example Foundation

Copies are made on a schedule and opened once a year, so nobody discovers a broken one during a crisis.

HABIT 2

Leave a Key

- A glossary of the terms you use
- A map of where things live
- A note on why the odd parts are odd

Example: Example Community

Every page starts with who it is for and where to begin.

HABIT 3

Welcome Readers

First Visit

- One clear front door
- A reply within days
- A small first task

Every Visit After

- Credit for their work
- A way to report mistakes
- A path to becoming a keeper

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What to Do Now

Pick one habit, start it this week and repeat it.

Archives and Projects

In an Archive	In an Open Project
Copyists	Mirrors and backups
A word list	A glossary
The last reader	The only maintainer
A margin note	A review comment

Every row asks one question: could someone else carry on?

Reading the Stones

- Copy it, explain it, open it
- Spread the record before the crisis

This Week

- Make one second copy
- Answer one newcomer

Further Reading

- Sources for every slide are in the post that goes with this talk.
- The speaker's stories come from the One Piece manga; each chapter is listed under Sources on this site's About page.
- example.org

Thank You

Questions

- Example link
- Another example link